

Marketing practices to promote indigenous fermented alcoholic beverages in the tropics

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35.1 Introduction

Alcoholic beverages are unique marketable products that are considered as a separate entity from food (Babor et al., 2010). The tropical world has a long history of preparing “non-commercial” fermented alcoholic beverages from a variety of raw materials such as roots and tubers, milk, cereals, fruits, and vegetables (Adelekan et al., 2008; Guyot, 2012). In virtually every corner of the world where fermented alcoholic beverages are consumed, indigenous fermented alcoholic beverages exist in one form or another (Haworth & Simpson, 2004). Regardless of their widespread prevalence, information about their existence in the context of marketing, sales, and distribution are limited (McKee et al., 2012; Novak, 2004).

The production process, especially marketing, distribution, and retail sale of alcohol, plays a significant role in consumer adoption and consumption (Jernigan & O'Hara, 2004). Alcohol marketing is described as any form of commercial communication or message designed to increase the recognition, appeal, and consumption of alcoholic beverages (WHO, 2010). In tropical climates, the marketing and distribution of fermented alcoholic beverages may be inadequate due to the lack of adequate technological infrastructure (State of the Tropics, 2017). This includes the fragmented nature of the marketing system and the involvement of high transaction costs (Deribe & Kassa, 2020). A limited number of marketing campaigns have been devoted in the past to promote regional, indigenous alcoholic products, while almost all alcohol advertised has been used to promote a specific foreign brand of alcohol (Ross et al., 2015).

Consequently, most of the alcoholic beverages consumed in developing or tropical countries are neither branded nor advertised products (Terblanche-Smit et al., 2014). Branded products are considered as the most important element in marketing as they embody physical, psychological, and symbolic features that collectively satisfy consumers (Kovacs et al., 2007). Marketing geared toward indigenous fermented alcoholic beverages is critical, given that alcohol advertising influences product and brand choice (Parry et al., 2012; Snyder et al., 2006). In addition, promotional efforts may aid in brand-switching within the industry (Terblanche-Smit et al., 2014). Marketing professionals thus need to strategically use the appropriate promotional mix (i.e., advertising, direct marketing, personal sales, and public relations) (Kovacs et al., 2007) to promote these products. This chapter highlights marketing practices involved in promoting indigenous fermented alcoholic beverages, as well as the challenges and opportunities facing the industry.

35.2 Consumer behavior toward alcoholic beverages, product marketing, and consumption

Consumers are constantly searching for new products on the marketplace, particularly an original taste, a novel brand, eye-catching packaging, and brilliant branding (Betancur et al., 2020; Dabija et al., 2021). However, millennials and Gen-Z consumers unlike baby boomers and Gen-X consumers mistrust traditional alcohol advertising approaches

(Fingerhut, 2016; Kellershohn, 2021). These groups value the integration of various technologies and smartphone apps, a shared digital opinion, and product customization (Elite Daily, 2015; Kellershohn, 2018).

An important influence in the marketing of alcoholic beverages is the level of their accessibility and the price at which they can be bought relative to other goods (Casswell, 2004). Price competition created by advertising lowers the prices of alcoholic beverages, thus increasing consumption (Sharma et al., 2017). Compared to previous generations, millennials base their alcohol purchase and consumption decisions on brand and product value experience, not convenience or price (Fona International, 2016; Kellershohn, 2018). In the tropics, the pattern of commercialization and consumption of indigenous alcoholic beverages is not the same across regions (Nassè, 2019). Alcoholic drinking patterns and behaviors are strongly shaped by the alcohol industry's largest transnational corporations (Walls et al., 2020).

According to consumer theory, demand for the various alcoholic beverages can be determined by own prices, prices of substitutes, and per capita income (Bentzen & Smith, 2018; Nelson, 2010). Owing to volume-based discounts offered by wholesalers, lower taxation, and high consumer demand, alcoholic drinks are relatively purchased more in low-middle income countries than high-income countries (Walls et al., 2020). However, if consumers are not motivated to consume the beverage, they pay little attention to the beverage's advertised price (Kersbergen & Field, 2017). Even so, marketing alcoholic beverages influence those with the intention to purchase and drink (Chen et al., 2005; WHO, 2018).

For the youth, the marketing of alcoholic brands has become an integral part of their everyday social life, with a growing culture of correlating brand labels and symbols with value (Elliott & Wattanasuwan, 1998; Padon et al., 2018). In particular, brands of fermented alcoholic beverages play an important role in communicating social status and aspirations (Casswell, 2004). For example, an American fortified fruit wine MD 20/20 (nicknamed Mad Dog) is particularly marketed and promoted to starter drinkers. The taste of alcohol in "Mad Dog" is disguised by a sweet and fruity flavor, a screw top that increases portability and high alcohol content for satisfying the need for rapid intoxication (Casswell, 2004).

On a broader social scale, alcohol marketing has a direct impact on social values (WHO, 2018). However, when cultural trends are negative concerning consumption, marketing alone is insufficient to increase the consumption of alcoholic beverages and vice versa (Woodside, 1999). Advertising effectiveness implicated by how consumers in different markets perceive and categorize information is moderated by cultural practices (Cacho-Elizondo et al., 2021). For instance, individualist cultures such as the United State of America (USA), expect fast, direct marketing while collectivist societies, such as Mexico count on building a brand relationship first (De Mooij, 2015). Thus, promoters need to select and use branding elements consistent with the cultural nuances of a market of interest (Cacho-Elizondo et al., 2021).

Lambert et al. (2010) considered religious beliefs to be a barrier to the sale and consumption of alcoholic drinks. In marketing to religious groups, there's a lack of rigorous marketing segmentation (Nassè, 2019). Marketers are mostly unaware of the fact that food beliefs and practices stem from religious beliefs (Kwon & Tamang, 2015). For example, in Bangladesh, the traditional food culture of the country is immensely influenced by myths and religious beliefs (Alam & Naser, 2020). Across the African continent, the consumption of alcoholic beverages is inversely related to the influence of Islamic prevalence (Kalema et al., 2016; Michalak & Trocki, 2006). While Islam was regarded as a threat to the local sorghum beer industry, Catholicism which dominated the social and cultural life of half the people in Manga, Burkina Faso, did not influence the attitude toward alcohol (Saul, 1981). In fact, drinking traditions were integrated into Christian festivals and most ceremonies were accompanied by consuming large amounts of traditional beer (Nassè, 2019).

Individualistic needs, personality traits, and one's character may also influence consumer behavior (Frank et al., 2015; Nayeem, 2012). As a result, predicting trends of future consumer behavior becomes difficult (O'Brien et al., 2018). A consumer behavior survey concluded, "People may *think* highly of your brand, but that doesn't necessarily predict *future behaviors*, such as remaining loyal or promoting a brand" (Veenstra & Murphy, 2021). Previous personal experience with alcohol dictates both advertising receptiveness and subsequent consumption (Ellickson et al., 2005). Regardless of these constraints, significant positive impacts of advertising on the consumption of alcoholic beverages such as wine, beer, and distilled spirits have been reported (Terblanche-Smit et al., 2014).

35.3 The marketing of indigenous fermented alcoholic beverages in the African tropics

Even with a smaller number of regular consumers, the overall consumption of alcohol in Africa is relatively high (Walls et al., 2020). Drinkers often engage in heavy episodic drinking, piking sales, and profitability (Esser & Jernigan, 2018). On the other hand, the industry is focused on marketing these products to women and young adults to influence

the adoption of heavy drinking patterns (Walls et al., 2020). Some of the employed marketing strategies involve the development of flavored products thought to be preferred by women and marketing that promotes an association between alcohol consumption and women's independence (Esser & Jernigan, 2018). Certain beer products have been promoted to mineworkers through the use of beerhalls, hostels, homesteads known as *shebeens*, and local pubs (Mager, 1999; Rogerson, 2019).

35.3.1 The promotion of artisanal indigenous fermented alcoholic beverages by individual and small-scale brewers

African women glorify beer above all alcoholic beverages. This is reflected in the Karimojong adage, “Beer is the cattle of women” (Dancause et al., 2010). The brewing, marketing, and selling of alcoholic beverages have been a full-time occupation for many women—playing an active role in food-processing microenterprises and the local economy (Kayodé et al., 2007; Mandel, 2004). In Togo, the manufacturing, marketing, and selling activities of *tchoukoutou* are primarily done by Togolese women (Dabija et al., 2021; Wilki, 2020). The same is true for *umqombothi* (Ikafafeng, 2008). The full scope of commercialization in the African economy redistributes wealth from men to women (Dancause et al., 2010).

The Ethiopian beer, *tella* is produced, sold domestically, and is not commercially available in the market (Lee et al., 2015). On the countryside roads where the drink is popularly sold, households indicate that they are selling their home-made *tella* through standing sticks with paper cups, bags, empty cans, or other objects on top (Fig. 35.1A) (Kloman, 2014; Lee et al., 2015). At the Friday market in Kanté, a wooden post with a calabash attached to it is an adequate sign that *tchoukoutou* is available (Seidl, 2021). In a creative Instagram post, a freelance reporter posted a picture of a wooden post with a calabash attached with the caption, “Here is a plaque that indicates where we sell *tchoukoutou*” (Fig. 35.1B) (Folly, 2020).

Vukanyi (a marula fruit cider) traders advertise their beer by placing unlabeled 2 litre bottles of the beer under giant trees next to the main road (Fig. 35.2B) (Shackleton, 2004). Various attempts such as the Mhala Development Centre (MDA) have been made to commercialize and market traditionally brewed beer products (Philip, 2008). To test the developed product, the cider was packaged and presented to a test market that didn't like the price point nor the taste (Fig. 35.2) (Philip, 2008). However, *Amarula* Cream, a marula-infused spirit is currently sold in over 100 countries and has had great success in several African countries, Brazil, Britain, Canada, Germany, and the USA (Masango, 2007).

The Ghanaian beer, *pito* has received some marketing attention despite not being a commercialized beverage (Lobnibe, 2016). Rock Empire Music organized an event “Party in a Slum,” where the local drink “*pito*” was the only branded beverage as part of promoting the product (Ghanainsideout, 2020). A product label contest to come up with the best branding design was also run online (Ros, 2021). A common marketing practice in West Africa is the custom of *lenga*, which involves offering prospective customers a small amount of free beer to demonstrate the quality (Saul, 1981; Wilki, 2020). As a marketing strategy, the amount of *lenga* may vary, with sellers often giving away very generous *lengas* to attract customers during periods of low demand (Saul, 1981). In Botswana, *khadi* sellers showcase the beverage in unlabeled mayonnaise jars near the entrances of their homes or under the shade of a publicly known giant tree (Motlhanka et al., 2018; von Rudloff, 2012). *Vukanyi* (marula fruit beer) exercises the same practice (Fig. 35.2B) (Leo, 2018).



FIGURE 35.1 (A) Indication of the availability of *tella* (Kloman, 2014) and (B) *tchoukoutou* (Folly, 2020)



FIGURE 35.2 (A) Beer brewers from MDA presenting “commercial” *vukanyi* (Philip, 2008) and (B) Artisanal brewers sharing unbranded *vukanyi* (Leo, 2018)



FIGURE 35.3 Some examples of *chibuku* marketing mediums: (A) competitions (Munashe, 2017), (B) sports sponsorships (Zimlive, 2021), (C) vehicle branding (Cohen, 2006), (D) press conferences (Hadley, 2017)

35.3.2 The promotion of commercialized indigenous fermented alcoholic beverages

Across Africa, only a few indigenous fermented alcoholic beverages have been commercialized and are actively marketed (Iwuoha, 2014). The promotion of *chibuku* is a case study in marketing indigenous fermented alcoholic beverages. Through a comprehensive marketing campaign, the beer is promoted on digital platforms, football leagues, posters, competition adverts, road signs, supermarkets, trucks, etc (Fig. 35.3) (Cohen, 2006; Zimlive, 2021). To date, *chibuku* is a popular alcoholic beverage in sub-Saharan Africa, including Botswana, South Africa, Zambia, and Zimbabwe (Dabija et al., 2021; Dandah & Chiweshe, 2021).

Beer has been a feature in a recent music video by a popular comedian (Akoonyatse, 2020). Similarly, “*Tchapalo*,” a song named after the Ivorian millet beer has over 2 million views on YouTube and is listed on popular streaming platforms such as iTunes, Spotify, Soundcloud, Deezer, and Tidal, (MZ, 2015). In the early 1980s, the famous African singer, Yvonne Chaka Chaka employed a similar marketing ploy with a pop song, “*Umqombothi*” (South African traditional beer) which was later featured in the opening scene of the movie, *Hotel Rwanda* (Mboti, 2012).

Palm alcoholic products are popular in certain parts of the African continent (Russo, 2021). For example, palm wine has found commercial success in Nigeria, with brands such as Pamii dominating the youth market (Gattuso, 2021). The wine is promoted through a savvy youth marketing campaign, involving an Instagram page full of attractive young

people lounging with the signature bottle at parties or beaches (Gattuso, 2021). The Ghanaian brand, Nkulenu's Palm Drink, exports over 25 million bottles of its branded palm wine to European and American countries (Iwuoha, 2014).

Another product that has made headway with tourists is *mbege*, a Tanzanian banana beer (Kellerman, 2015). In Rwanda, the banana beer (*tonto*) is marketed bizarrely. Foreign visitors read about the beverage when they visit the National Museum and are afterward taken to convents to buy and enjoy the beer (Handman, 2009). Yuliyana, a Rwandan-based indigenous beverages production company, uses Twitter as its main marketing outlet, rigorously employing hashtags and mentions on posted products (ORG, 2020; Rwanda-FDA, 2021)

35.4 The marketing of indigenous fermented alcoholic beverages in the Asian tropics

The role of marketing fermented alcoholic beverages and subsequent consumption in Asian countries is rarely discussed (Jiang et al., 2017). Fortunately, commercialization, marketing, and related services have been considered crucial in the development of the agro-industrial sector of Bangladesh (Tamang et al., 2016). A dramatic increase in beer production between 1996 and 2000 was observed in Sri Lanka, with the production of "Lion" beer doubling in the year 1998/1999 (Wujayanayake, 2001). During the same period, a market shift from *arrack* to beer was statically visible (Wujayanayake, 2001). From 2000 to 2019 Asia was shown to be the fastest-growing alcohol market, with more than 30% of global alcohol sales in 2014 and an estimated increase of 176% (Jiang et al., 2017). With no state monopoly and alcohol license requirements for the production and sale of alcohol, India has become one of the largest alcohol producers in the world (Chakrabarti et al., 2012).

35.4.1 The promotion of artisanal indigenous fermented alcoholic beverages by individual and small-scale brewers

Among Asian tropical countries, India has the most diverse artisanal alcoholic beverages, including *buza*, *chhang*, *daru*, and *toddy* (Sawhney, 2020; Tamang et al., 2016). In India, most indigenous fermented alcoholic beverages such as *jaanr*, *hadi*, and *chullu* are produced, marketed, and sold in rural areas, through the use of community festivals and open vending places (Chakrabarti et al., 2012). *Chhang* "Nepali Beer" is promoted to tourists through stories of myths and legends (Sarda, 2017). The beer is also marketed digitally through a fictional brand that promotes indigenous fermented alcoholic beverages over foreign alcohol brands (Fig. 35.4) (Lin, 2019). *Daru*, a distilled liquor, is a reoccurring trope in *chutney* music, Afro-Caribbean novels, and *daru* poetic performances (Mohabir, 2020).

The marketing and distribution of tropical jackfruit (*Artocarpus heterophyllus*) wine largely depend on middlemen as there are no regularized marketing and distribution channels (Mittal et al., 2021). The Meghalaya government's initiative has made substantial investments to package, brand, and promote the trade of jackfruit products of small and medium enterprises (SMEs) and nano-enterprises (focusing on women homemakers) (Vinayak, 2021). The course of action included advertising campaigns, quality, testing and certification, electronic and social media outlets, buyer-seller meets, B2B meetings, roadshows, vending kiosks, and trade fairs (Mittal et al., 2021). Adequate marketing of this wine is projected to increase its value (Girijashankar, 2011).



FIGURE 35.4 Concept branding and packaging for *chhang* (Lin, 2019)

35.4.2 The promotion of commercialized indigenous fermented alcoholic beverages

Arrack is an alcoholic spirit distilled from the fermented sap of coconut flowers, typically produced in South Asia (Fig. 35.5) (Sawhney, 2020). The beverage is mainly produced and consumed in Sri Lanka and has become popular in the United Kingdom (UK) and often served in some of London's modern restaurants, like Dishoom and Hoppers (Budhkar, 2016). *Judima*, a popular rice wine in India made headlines when it qualified for a geographical indication (GI) tag, which gives local producers exclusive brand protection and the promotion of trade of traditional knowledge-based GI products in national and international markets (Gogoi, 2016).

The beverage is exhibited yearly over a 3-day festival organized by Trend MMS, and is supported by Assam Tourism (Barman, 2017). The festival, which is primarily focused on promoting the beer to a wider market, is also streamed on YouTube (Barman, 2017; Daniel & Roohi, 2016). Bottling and professionally branding the beer with new avatars will make it more acceptable and authentic among tourists (Barman, 2017). The Xaj brand is sold and marketed in its wine store, Twitter, Facebook (including a Facebook page), LinkedIn, and internet pages (Bhattacharyya, 2018).

Toddy, a palm wine is a favorite among tropical Asian countries (Aidoo et al., 2006). It is also minutely present in Europe, with fair acceptance as captured by a German bottled brand, “The real cult drink from the tropics finally in Europe” (Palms, 2021). Brand names such as DesmondJi and TAATAS are promoted by advertising bottled products on social media and other digital platforms (Bathija, 2018; Singh, 2018). The same is true for Nepalese *rakshi* (Karki et al., 2016). The wide-scale promotion of these beverages seems to depend on travel guides and tourists' word-of-mouth (Welsch, 2018). The worldwide leader in news, Cable News Network (CNN) ranked *rakshi* 41st on the “World's 50 Most Delicious Drinks” list, superseding popular drinks such as Fanta, Red Bull, Mango Lassi, and Guinness (Cheung, 2018). CNN's recognition of *rakshi* is expected to attract alcoholic drinks lovers from around the globe (Nepal24hours, 2012).

35.5 The marketing of indigenous fermented alcoholic beverages in the American tropics

In the American tropics, there's an important market of regular consumers of distilled spirits, wine, and beer (Mart, 2011; Woodside, 1999). As a result, the “informal” trade of indigenous fermented alcoholic beverages coexists with the established commercial market (Carlini et al., 2012). In South America, artisanal and small-scale level production and marketing practices are performed by family, usually four members with the women responsible for bottling and tasting (Brito et al., 2020). If needed, the family may contract an additional workforce (Brito et al., 2020). The production of non-commercial alcoholic beverages in the American tropics involves a mixture of traditional, non-mechanic labor (Zapata & Nabhan, 2003). For commercial alcoholic beverages, the most advanced production and brand management tools are used (Chávez, 2006).

35.5.1 The promotion of artisanal indigenous fermented alcoholic beverages by individual and small-scale brewers

Several countries in the Andean zone of South America produce and branded *pisco* to a domestic and international market (Faria et al., 2003). Although the beverage is significantly consumed in Chile and Peru, it is almost unknown elsewhere and local demand is stagnant (Bordeu et al., 2012). Fortunately, *pisco* is well-accepted by foreigners that visit Chile, creating the possibility to increase international recognition (Faria et al., 2003). In the Chilean region of Coquimbo, The *Pisco Route* at the Elqui Valley complements the region's tourism activities, including guided visits to traditional *pisqueras* (Lacoste & Navarrete, 2014; Mathis et al., 2017). A similar situation exists in Peru, with visitors



FIGURE 35.5 (A) Ceylon—Sri Lanka's oldest commercial producer of *arrack* and (B) Ceylon's upmarket *arrack* (BBC, 2019)

able to learn about product development and have the experience of tasting Peruvian *pisco* (López, 2015; Mathis et al., 2017). These routes and visitor centers are effective vehicles to tell an alcohol brand's story to interested visiting consumers (Kellershohn, 2018).

Sorrel, a traditional Caribbean hibiscus liqueur was crafted and successfully marketed long before its commercialization (Kellerman, 2015). The commercial branded version, Sorel, is set to be re-launched this summer following a USD 50 million fund investment from the American whiskey producer, Uncle Nearest (Malczewski, 2021). The marketing campaign focused on competitions and reviews, with its success stories appearing on Punch, yahoo, The New York Times, Food & Wine, and Black Enterprise (Pomranz, 2021; Rense, 2020). In Jamaica, Red Stripe created an advertising contest for local creatives to produce advertisements for a showcase on *Instagram* (LoopNews, 2020).

35.5.2 The promotion of commercialized indigenous fermented alcoholic beverages

A recent increase in the demand for *cachaça*, the most consumed distilled beverage in Brazil, forced producers to invest heavily in marketing to ensure that their products appealed to an international market (Carlini et al., 2012). *Cachaça* is produced both artisanally and industrially and its commercialization by the government and private companies is a textbook example of successful marketing (Brito et al., 2020; Paiva et al., 2018). Among thousands of *cachaça* brands that exist in Brazil, only a few have achieved national and international coverage (Miszputen, 2007; Scanavini et al., 2012). Leblon's marketing strategy was elaborate, with their public relations campaign receiving coverage in Newsday, New York Post, the Wall Street Journal, New York Daily News, US Weekly, Crain's Business, as well as mass-circulation through elite magazines such as Forbes, Vogue, Fortune and GQ (Bull, 2017; Coelho et al., 2014; Lewis, 2014; Mendal, 2020).

By manipulating keywords that ranked the site high in search engine results, the marketing firm, SendTraffic.com, created an interactive internet campaign that drove substantial traffic on the company website (Coelho et al., 2014). Additional online marketing of *cachaça* included promotions based on a mailing list, social media networks, and the Leblon's website (Coelho et al., 2014; Strenk, 2015). To promote the drink at events, Leblon sponsored the Nightclub and Bar Trade Show, Leblon Beach Volleyball at Nikki Beach, Miami Music Conference, New York Fashion Week, and a benefit concert by The Black Eyed Peas (Coelho et al., 2014). Furthermore, special events were held in influential establishments including the Four Seasons Hotel Miami, Nikki Beach, Hotel on Rivington, Fogo de Chão, and Kittichai (Coelho et al., 2014).

Tequila, described as the "Mexican par excellence" has a long marketing history (Mathis et al., 2017). *Los de Abajo* (The Underdogs), a fictional novel published in 1915 made significant mention of tequila's flavor, packaging, and its role in Mexican patriotism (Gaytán, 2017). From 1935 to 1959, *tequila* was famously praised in cinemas—its themes, actors, and songs (Chávez, 2006; Gaytán, 2017). At the time, the most prevalent genre, the *comedia ranchera* (melodrama), regularly featured the adventures of *tequila*-drinking male protagonists (Chávez, 2006; Gaytán, 2017). Over the decades, *tequila*-drinking female protagonists have been popularised through print media (Fig. 35.6) (Reed, 2014).

Tequila's reputation and fame as "everyman's" drink were highlighted by *ranchera* songs sung by *charros* (Gaytán, 2017). In 1996, Casa Cuervo, orchestrated a publicity stunt by acquiring a small island in the Caribbean creating a "nation" called "República de Cuervo" (Chávez, 2006). Two years later, a marketing tactic involved the premier of two different telenovelas—*La mentira* and *Azul tequila*, in which the main characters produced *tequila* (Chávez, 2006). In 2010, tequila encrusted with 4000 diamonds in a platinum-coated bottle was priced at USD 3.5 million and toured auction showrooms in Dubai, London, and New York, making worldwide headlines (Gaytán, 2017).

The pre-historic honey wine, "mead" is making a trendy comeback through the sale of branded mead products online, in craft meaderies, beer festivals, pubs, supermarkets, and historical attractions (Ramalhosa et al., 2011). The American Mead Makers Association, which promotes mead and brings together meaderies has made the drink fashionable in America, causing a huge spike in demand (Pereira et al., 2017). Seguin's Seventh Annual Mead Fest hosts the Texas Mead Cup, a homemade and professional mead competition (Elizarraras, 2018). Mead has been made attractive to modern consumers through popular TV series including *Game of Thrones*, *Vikings*, and Netflix's *Ragnarok*, as well as the popular video game, *Assassin's Creed Valhalla* (Aitchison, 2021).

35.6 Challenges and drawbacks

Some challenges and opportunities exist in catalyzing a market for indigenous alcoholic beverages that have not been previously commoditised (Philip, 2008). In many instances, these beverages have been previously stigmatized, their consumption discouraged and their outlook distorted by colonial powers (Paiva et al., 2018; Rogerson, 2019). By the



FIGURE 35.6 Tequila advertisements over the years: 1945 (A) (Radovanovic, 2014), 1962 (B) (Reed, 2014), 2001 (C) (Plume21, 2021), 2021 (Reed, 2021)

seventeenth century, for example, Portuguese colonists who used *cachaça* to barter for slaves prohibited its production, trade, and consumption when it began over-competing Portuguese liquors (Miszputen, 2007).

In developing countries, especially in Africa, research and product development is not supported despite the existence of strong economic markets for these products (Guyot, 2012). Traditionally fermented alcoholic beverages specifically face complex quality hurdles since they are not usually processed or packaged as modern products (Hossain & Rahman, 2019). There's also a lack of standard procedure in the production of most traditional alcoholic beverages (Hlangwani et al., 2020). The difficulty lies in computing the technical coefficients of production due to the nature of production, social obligations, and economic transactions involved (Dredawa, 2019). As a result, marketing practitioners are faced with the challenge of efficiently building brand awareness in the minds of consumers (Terblanche-Smit et al., 2014).

As highlighted by Walls et al. (2020), "The relationships between large industrial producers and smaller traders can be highly variable, with the distribution of formally produced alcohol taking place alongside the distribution of unrecorded alcohol through informal unregistered vendors." Few studies argue that consumer demand for high-quality, safe alcoholic beverages, especially by urban populations may stimulate industrialization, commercialization, and widespread marketing (Nout & Sarkar, 1999). Furthermore, many households are eager for the availability of ready-to-drink alcoholic beverages at retail stores (Burrell, 2019). Nonetheless, progress in satisfying demand has been poor given the minimal effort to promote indigenous fermented alcoholic beverages on social media platforms such as Facebook, Instagram, Twitter, and Pinterest (Gupta et al., 2018; McKee et al., 2012).

Sales and taxation data is also inadequate for quantifying the consumption of products from non-market-based sources (Walls et al., 2020). Furthermore, these products face the intractable challenges of volume, price, and productivity ratios (Philip, 2008). Over the years, the issue of pricing has presented a unique challenge, especially for African economies (Philip, 2008). Prices of alcoholic beverages are superficially stable and fluctuate daily depending on consumer demand (Philip, 2008). Furthermore, price differentiation between artisanal products and advertised branded alcoholic products exists, affecting access and price sensitivity (Terblanche-Smit et al., 2014). Thus, branding and marketing indigenous fermented alcoholic beverages may isolate a large proportion of the population as in the case of *vukany* (marula fruit cider) (Philip, 2008; Terblanche-Smit et al., 2014).

American tropical countries such as Brazil, Mexico, Cuba, Ecuador, and Costa Rica face the challenge of the widespread sale and distribution of counterfeit alcoholic products (Rutledge, 2017; Tobiassen, 2014). Counterfeit alcohol is described, “Alcohol that is sold as a branded product when it is not that product but an inferior one. Counterfeit alcohol is presented in counterfeit packaging to deceive the buyer into believing it to be the legitimate brand” (Spencer et al., 2018). These products are mainly sold and purchased from e-commerce platforms where regulation is almost non-existent (Maroney, 2020). Incidents of counterfeit alcoholic beverages appearing in news media outlets are minimized (Tobiassen, 2014). As traditional marketing channels continue to downplay the impact of counterfeit alcoholic drinks, consumers will continue to fall victim as they use e-commerce platforms to search for competitive prices, shopping convenience, and prompt delivery (Maroney, 2020; Noel et al., 2020).

Psychotropic substances such as cannabis, nicotine, and Adderall also compete with these beverages for “share of throat” (Kleczkowska et al., 2016; Paz et al., 2004). The pursuit to compete with the drugs has led to the addition of harmful agents to increase the potency of indigenous fermented alcoholic beverages (Dayimani, 2020; Haworth & Simpson, 2004). In the last decade, laced alcoholic beverages have led to deaths of at least 800 Indians, 122 Salvadorans, 80 Ugandans, 35 Mexicans, 23 Nigerians, and 20 Afghans (BBC, 2010; Dalton, 2000; Mahajan, 2020; Pugliese, 2008; Sowole, 2015; The Guardian, 2020). These incidents negatively affect the image and credibility of indigenous fermented alcoholic beverages (Haworth & Simpson, 2004; Yu et al., 2018). Negative publicity harms consumer perceptions and purchase intention (Ahluwalia et al., 2000; Morteza Bagi et al., 2015).

35.7 Opportunities and future developments

Brewers must be creative and innovative when formatting their products to meet customer requirements and build a market centered on consumer needs (Dabija et al., 2021). These tools and strategies in the value chain are essential for market adoption of indigenous fermented alcoholic beverages (Botha, 2019). This includes alcoholic beverages aimed at a new generation of young consumers who are culturally and demographically different from beer and spirits drinkers of Anglo-industrial cultures and traditional wine drinkers of Mediterranean cultures (Casswell, 2004; Kellershohn, 2021). Marketing experts thus must employ new, evidence-based marketing strategies to advertise products to distinctive consumer groups (Paiva et al., 2018). A crucial marketing and promotional strategy involves the development of new products which are specially packaged and promoted to meet the needs of specific groups of people (Jones et al., 2008).

While developed to attract new drinkers, new products are designed to keep established drinkers often lost to changes such as aging, marriages and mortgages, health complications, and death (Casswell, 2004). Marketers must select and employ carefully selected marketing and promotional mixes in synergy with the changes of the product’s life cycle (Terblanche-Smit et al., 2014). In creating campaigns to promote indigenous fermented alcoholic beverages, marketing practitioners need to take advantage of the internet and digital channels which are generally not restricted and over-regulated (Veenstra & Murphy, 2021). Practitioners can also utilize social marketing approaches used by governments and international organizations to facilitate desirable behavioral changes (Kubacki & Szablewska, 2019). Unlike conventional marketing channels, social media is an effective bi-directional advertising platform able to target specific groups and communicate directly with consumers (Lim et al., 2016).

Apart from social media, alcohol brands can employ new and innovative marketing approaches. To engage consumers, brands such as United Spirits Limited, Heineken, and Johnnie Walker are now using chatbots to provide consumers with bartending solutions, coupons (e.g., free drinks, transport), recipe catalogs, recommendations, guided tasting experiences, ordering options for alcohol and mixer supplies, and customer care (Cravens, 2017; Mittal, 2020). Internet of things technologies are also gaining traction in the alcohol marketing space (Demir & Dincer, 2020; Violino et al., 2020). The Caribbean rum-based liqueur, Malibu, developed an on-demand drink delivery system that allows customers to signal staff by twisting the bottom of a bar-connected cup (Kellershohn, 2018).

Recently, mobile apps that have a gamification or entertainment aspect have become a central feature in alcohol marketing and consumption (Eagle et al., 2014; Westgate & Holliday, 2016). Beam Suntory partnered with Shazam to launch an app with immersive experience features, including mini-games, 3D animations, 360-degree videos, and product visualizations (Azfar, 2017; Vanian, 2017). Virtual reality experiential marketing (including augmented reality, embodied robots, avatars, and smart displays) can enable consumers to tour digital locations of breweries, distilleries, taprooms, wine farms, and bars (Durl et al., 2018; Smilansky, 2017). Similarly, the use of big data analytics can aid brands in tailor-making alcoholic beverages to satisfy personal preferences (Grewal et al., 2020). In addition, brands can make use of digital loyalty programs to reward regular purchasers (Dlamini & Chinje, 2019; Garzon & Taylor, 2016).

Successfully marketing alcoholic beverages in the digital age requires open innovation (OI) activities (Herhausen et al., 2020; Thach et al., 2016; Zacharias et al., 2020). To strategically implement OI activities, alcohol brands must make use of social media influencers (Barlatier & Josseland, 2018; Green et al., 2012). By engaging in OI activities, independent third-party endorsers, wine influencers (WIs), have become successful social media influencers in the wine marketing arena (Ingrassia et al., 2020; Lord Ferguson et al., 2019). Influencer marketing affects consumer preferences, brand acceptance, brand loyalty, purchase decisions, and product choice (Chopra et al., 2021; Dwivedi et al., 2021; Wielki, 2020). A journal article titled “Picture Me Drinking: Alcohol-Related Posts by Instagram Influencers Popular Among Adolescents and Young Adults” indicates that lifestyle influencers’ alcohol posts were positive and showed a social context, with a considerable number of posts showing a clear alcohol brand (Hendriks et al., 2020). This, together with the choice of influencer and number of followers, urges consumers to favor both the product and the brand (Dolan, 2016; Knoll & Matthes, 2017; Westgate & Holliday, 2016; Taillon et al., 2020).

By exploiting the functional or esthetic properties of the materials used, packaging indigenous fermented alcoholic beverages may increase their acceptability among consumers, policymakers, and regulators (Kersbergen & Field, 2017; Ramos et al., 2015). Advances in the packaging industry have been made, including the use of intelligent packaging, the development of multilayer systems, and environmentally friendly materials (Baiano et al., 2015; Marsh & Bugusu, 2007; Pati et al., 2010). As captured by the marketing prodigy, Steve Luttmann, “A bottle is a cheap plane ticket, a cheap way to experience another culture” (Coelho et al., 2014). A recent promotional trend is the adoption of active packaging technologies (Ramos et al., 2015). For example, bottle labels with NFC technology can allow consumers to use NFC-enabled smartphones to access brand information and interact with the product (Ramos et al., 2015). To illustrate, consumers can scan a QR code on a bottle of mead to go to a cocktail menu (Aitchison, 2021).

Policies addressing the informal market need to be implemented to legalize and regulate the production and sale of indigenous non-commercial beverages (ICAP, 2008). The implementation of certification and GI tagging, which have been both successful in South Asia and South America, can have positive implications in other areas such as Africa and tropical islands (Gaytán, 2017). In Mexico, The Tequila Regulatory Council (CRT) “verify and certify that all Tequilas complied with the Official Mexican Standard (Norma Oficial Mexicana),” (Faria et al., 2003). Public policymakers should protect consumers from a plethora of counterfeit alcoholic beverages by resisting weakening transparent and accountable systems of manufacturing, distribution, and sale (Maroney, 2020). These systems allow industry regulators to rapidly react to and track product-related problems and promptly remove problematic products from the marketplace (Gaytán, 2017).

35.8 Conclusion

Given the number of indigenous fermented alcoholic beverages across the tropics, the current body of knowledge on marketing practices and their role in consumption preferences is limited. In addition, most existing studies fail to assess the effects of social, political, and technological advancement on these practices. Fortunately, free access to digital platforms on the internet has afforded some publicity and promotional traction for several alcoholic beverages. As the overall quality, branding, and packaging aspects of these products are improved, more indigenous fermented alcoholic beverages will be marketed effectively.

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